

Pulse and voice in *The Waste Land*
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Abstract

There's no lack of critical works about musical aspects of *The Waste Land*; still, few of these engage directly the signifier of the poem, as they discuss the content and meaning of references rather than typesetting, metrics and pronunciation. In specular fashion, those works that do tackle signifiers don't investigate them in musical terms¹. This research focuses on musical analysis of *The Waste Land*, as it graphically looks on the page and as it sounds recorded on phonograph, claiming it can assist interpretation.

First, I examine how Eliot systematically uses typographic space as a rigorous musical tool (a 3/4 time direction), resulting in a shift in reading performance from qualitative to quantitative metre (this not being a "natural" consequence, but the result of a very conscious work). The extent to which Pound influenced Eliot in some of these realizations leads us to look for complex musical values, so-called metric modulations, in free verse, empirically testing limit speed ratios of reading performance, in the attempt of establishing accurate subdivisions of the text.

Then, Eliot's essay *The Three Voices of Poetry* is put in connection with the changes in pulse in the recordings that I associated with properties of free verse theorized by Pound, asserting these are instrumental in representing and diversifying inner thought, rhetorical argument and dramatic speech (by means of their respectively different relationships with their addressees and contexts).

It is argued how metric modulation, alongside a more general semantic modulation—a change in context flagged by the shifting of grammar operators, like personal pronouns and correlatives—works as a means employed to create variety inside a *continuum*. I therefore derive some logical conclusions about the nature of the transformations of the speaker in *The Waste Land*, highlighting the dichotomy between the mimeses that drive the swift turnovers of the poem (often leading the reader to infer multiple voices) and the slower metamorphosis that keeps it together, ensuring its horizontal development from such abrupt vertical leaps.

¹ with some notable, but scarce, exceptions. Hawlin, *Eliot Reads The Waste Land: Text and Recording* (1992), Swigg, *Sounding The Waste Land: T.S. Eliot's 1935 Recording* (2001) and Chambers, *The Peace of The Waste Land* (2015) take on the analysis of the recordings, but they don't discuss it in musical terms; the last essay comes closer to our intention, but it moves from an opposite appraisal of typesetting. Micakovic, *T.S. Eliot's Voice: A Cultural History* (2015) goes deep in examining the historical importance of the phonograph recordings, but, insofar as interpretative issues are in cause, I come to different theoretical answers (see discussion about *melopoeia* as not opposed to metrical maneuvering further on) and draw interpretative conclusions about *the poem* and not about the recordings themselves. Brooke, Hammond & Hirst operate with *The Waste Land's* written signifier (see Brooke *et al*, 2015), but their scope is that of automation (using the poem as constant term and not as variable), not literary criticism.

On the other hand, Christopher Ricks's conference on auditory imagination (2013) is used as a starting point for this paper; even more relevant an article not about Eliot's, but about Pound's mastership of rhythms: Langman, *Cutting a Shape in Time* (2002) is inspirational for the second part of this text. It is not surprising that pivotal speculation is coming from this direction, having Eliot studied *il miglior fabbro's* technique for years: see in particular Eliot, *Ezra Pound: His Metric and Poetry* (1917), Pound, *The Treatise on Harmony*, contained in Pound, *Antheil* (1927) and Pound, *The ABC of Reading* (1934).

I. Typesetting observations

Sir Christopher Ricks, during a lecture² on Eliot's "auditory imagination", carefully examines unexpected pronunciation and/or metrical scan of some thirty words throughout different recordings; he underlines³ how dramatically different from what one could expect Eliot sometimes goes, and, even if he states⁴ that there is no point in asking if Eliot had the right to do so, he admits⁵ that criticizing him for not having made it sufficiently clear in the poem would be licit. This paper inserts itself within this framework.

I like to start with the first explicit (and most frequently analyzed⁶) musical moment in *The Waste Land*, namely the quotation from *Tristan*'s first Act "*Frisch weht der Wind / Der Heimat zu / Mein Irisch Kind / Wo weilest du?*". Often⁷ critics in search of "musical" interpretations refrain from looking into the recordings of the poem, because, as they promptly noticed when they first listened to them, it is "not sung". The fact that Eliot didn't seize the chance to sing those lines stands as a *memento* for actual or wannabe directors and composers conspiring transpositions⁸.

Nevertheless, in typical Eliotian fashion, the wise stone lies right below the stunning opaqueness. The reductive idea that the lines are "not sung" by Eliot relies on the fact that the pitch of the vowels does not follow the well-known Wagnerian melody, yet, the fact that Wagner's notation is not implemented regarding pitch does not mean that it is not respected at all. Eliot rightly thought that, though music and poetry have many points of contact, they have differences too. Specifically, the rhythm generated by the different lengths of uttered syllables is a perfectly compatible common ground, whose notation needs no translation, whereas pauses and melisms pertain to music's domain and need to be transformed to be represented in poetry⁹. If we go back to Eliot's recordings of the poem and take careful notice of the rhythmical pattern of those lines, we will see that the "regular" expected metrical reading is not followed. What should be a plain (albeit nervous) u ù u ù | u ù u ù | u ù u ù | u ù u ù (musically analyzable as four groups in 2/4 time, what Pound called "rocking-horse rhythms") is actually vocalized as the rocking u – u – | u – u – | u – u – | u – u – (musically in 3/4 time: four iambic μέτρα) which definitely sounds more appropriate (not only Eliot's, but every recording I know follows this scan) and that is also a correct rhythmical rendition of Wagner's score (pauses, which, again, for Eliot remain music's different domain, excluded). So, the reader of *The Waste Land* "sings" those lines; he represents the singing with the main musical tool inherently proper to poetry: rhythm.

² <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=zhkcrQ09YdU>

³ *ibid.* 32:08

⁴ *ibid.* 29:26

⁵ *ibid.* 32:52

⁶ a propos, consider the 1989 article by S. Wintle, eloquently titled *Wagner and The Waste Land—Again*.

⁷ that would be an *elenco infinito*. One for all: Paterson, *Frisch weht der Wind etc* (2016).

⁸ on the relationship between *kitsch* and the Holy, see Calasso, *La rovina di Kasch* (1983).

⁹ pitch does have a poetic representation through intonation, but this topic goes beyond the scope of this article; see references to *melopoeia* in Pound, *The ABC of Reading*.

Still: “Is it sufficiently clear in the poem?”. Where do we find the directions (within the text) to apply these rules, *there* where they should be applied and there *only*?

First I’d like to say that to obtain such an effect Eliot needn’t use as much information as contained in Wagner’s score, not even considering the sole rhythmical aspects. The only thing one needs to is shifting from qualitative English metre to the Greek quantitative one. What in the English model are stressed syllables in the Greek system become long syllables: u ù u ù becomes u – u –; 2/4 becomes 3/4. So, theoretically, just one indication would be necessary to quote Wagner and justify the ear-friendly reading of those lines. And, actually, *there is* one aspect of those four lines which is peculiar to them and that keeps them apart from the preceding and following ones: typographic space. Eliot, who never liked wasting one whole word with only one meaning, wrote “The disposition of the lines on the page [...] can never give an *exact* notation of the author’s metrics. The chief value of the author’s record [...] is a guide to the rhythms.”¹⁰. So, for Eliot the goal of recording the poems was in the first place an assistance to typesetting¹¹. The fact that he thought that the disposition of the lines on the page was not univocal enough to represent the metrics correctly means that unusual dispositions of lines on the page are attempts to represent directions in the field of rhythm (unlike calligrams or concrete poetry). If we follow this trail, for example with another Wagnerian reference, that to the third Act of *Götterdämmerung* found in *The Fire Sermon*¹², we discover a promising homogeneity. Again, what is fundamentally an even foot gains “breath” shifting from a 2/4 to a 3/4 by means of the doubling in length of stressed syllables. So we don’t read “Red sails” as a pyrrhic ù ù but as a spondaic – – and “The barges wash” doesn’t sound u ù u ù but u – u – (exact match with “*Frisch weht der Wind*” etc.). The cross-rhythm created by the waves breaking against the sides of the boat while it turns right and left around the Isle of Dogs is represented in its horizontal development; two very different and distinct attainments see the waltzy u u – u – (“With the turning tide”) and the breaking of line division with the lonely “Wide” followed by the triple “To leeward, swing on the heavy spar.”: – / u – u | – u u – u –¹³, an amphibrach followed by a dactyl and a cretic that juxtapose the “Swing” of the sails to that of African syncopation, back to the common mimetic origin of water drumming (a way to talk with the river¹⁴). The second verse gives us a steadier track, with the boat’s alignment to the winds restored and the Thames’ dilation that follows its bending round the Isle of Dogs¹⁵: noteworthy the final inversion “White towers” marking the end of the verse (*anceps* trochee).

But is it right to infer that the typographic space has this precise metrical significance, building a theory out of two examples?

¹⁰ from the sleeve notes to the recording of *Four Quartets*. Italics mine.

¹¹ in writing this I knowingly depart from most interpretations of Eliot’s words, and most relevantly from Chambers (2015) in *The Hilltop Review*: Vol. 7: Iss. 2, pg 74.

¹² the first two verses (*insieme*) of the so-called “Song of the Thames Daughters”, lines 266-291.

¹³ Eliot actually utters – / u – u | – u u ù – – in both versions, but this singular exception to the supposed rules, during such a difficult rhythmical passage, could be an error on Eliot’s side.

¹⁴ about Eliot’s intuition that Jazz represented one perfect superimposition of modernity and primitivism, see Chinitz, *Eliot’s Cultural Divide* (particularly Chapter 4); about poetry and music as originally imitative, see, for example, Winn, *Unsuspected Eloquence: A History of the Relations between Poetry and Music* (1981).

¹⁵ and that is meant to continue exponentially till Margate sands, and maybe Carthage.

Incidentally, there is an interesting variation on the theme in the Song of the Thames Daughters, operating in the refrain at the end of every verse; in addition to the *bonus* typographic spacing the whole section “benefits”, there a second level is implemented: the “Weielala, weielas” that end each section are pushed further in the middle of the page, and the reading, once more, is affected. This time one notices the change not in the metrics as in the *tempo*, that speeds up with a 4/3 ratio. What is the significance of this? The weielala weielas’ maintaining the 3/4 rhythm when a typographic space is added implies their changing of *tempo*, as in as much the previous two examples we analyzed maintaining of *tempo* implied their changing of rhythm (and of bar length: 3/2). So, not only the typographic space is meant as a particular indication (quantitative metre), and not only there is a constant ratio (3/2: it is called *hemiola*) between quantitative and qualitative readings of the same metre, but when juxtaposed it is also meant to be cumulative¹⁶. This will result clearer examining pulse ratios in qualitative metre in the next paragraph.

This feature, besides flexibility, brings with it some ambiguity, which might have added to Eliot’s dissatisfaction with the transparency of his tool. The same application of the 3/2 ratio appears again in the “Water Song” in *What the Thunder Said*¹⁷, this time with the text positioned to the left, almost at the base margin. The predicted shift to quantitative metre is performed as expected, but here the *tempo* is slowed down. This increasing subtlety in the directions might reflect, one more time, a worry for the communicability of the directions themselves and the wish to train the reader: first the shift to qualitative reading is presented without change of *tempo*, then that new feature is added with the weielalas, and, eventually, the Water Song demands both changing of *tempo* (now 3/4 slower, not 4/3 faster as before) *and* metre at the same time, without progression. What the typographic directions wholly miss is the curve that Eliot embeds *accelerando* until the centre of the song and then *rallentando* until at the end the initial *tempo* is restored. These adjustments, that in musical scores are not notated in opposition to the base *tempo* but rather in addition to it, are some of those that only recordings can communicate and that made Eliot so committed to the task.

Last, we shall account for the other major use of typesetting in the poem, a direction that Eliot knew would have never lead to confusion with the ones examined above and that, on the contrary, would have induced instinctively its proper execution in the reader. This is the *anacrusis*, *arsis* or *levare* direction that informs us that the anticipated word(s) are intended to be read before the first strong beat (*battere*) in the line, as notes belonging to a preceding bar¹⁸. This use of the space is characteristic to the second section and to the “Nerves Dialogue” in particular. It’s nice to notice how also this *levare* direction is used to summon specific musical reminiscences, when, leaving one syllable alone at the beginning of a sentence (“Do / you know nothing?” “But / O O O O that Shakespeherian rag”) Eliot recreates for us the trademark rhythmical pattern of ragtime and swing: u / ù | u / ù | u / ù | u / ù, etc.

¹⁶ more precisely, multiplicative; if we take 72 bpm as the *tempo* on which the 3/4 rhythm is constructed, then its accelerated (placed to the right) value will be of 96 and the slowed down (placed to the left) of 54 bpm. These proportions are parallel to the 8/9 ratio later found in *tempi*: 64, 72, 81 bpm. See also note 23 for a better appreciation of why Eliot uses these proportions.

¹⁷ lines 346-358.

¹⁸ see Langman, 2002, p. 24, for identical analysis of Poundian verse.

II. *Poème symphonique*, for five metronomes

In the first part we analyzed rhythmical issues and I pointed out the underlying connection between rhythm and *tempo* (musical speed, inversely proportional to pulse length, measured in beats per minute); now we will further investigate timing issues in Eliot's recordings of the poem.

The main problem I want to single out is: are there intentional *tempo* changes in the recordings of *The Waste Land*? And if so, can we find any kind of direction inside the text that could "legitimate" such changes?

Popular music got us used to metronomical pulses and straight timing variations, whereas classical music often works with *accelerandi* and *rallentandi*. But, being music's development rooted in time, both are built on the backbone of a rigorous, regular, beat; the *accelerandi*, *rallentandi* and *rubati* of classical music are superimposed to such a beat (that permits coordination between different musicians), and are not to be confused with its changes (that are not progressive, but vertically instantaneous, unless otherwise noted). On the contrary, actor-playing and poetry reading at the time (still under the influence of Romanticism) freely fluctuated in instinctive forms. Pound was decided to give poetry the same rhythmical rigour found in music, inveighing against the use of variation of speed as a substitution for the rhythms of quantitative metre; he also claimed the existence of a universal "Great Bass", meaning that all pulses are absolute ratios. Eliot did perform his poetry readings with *accelerandi* and *rallentandi* (so much so that Micakovic maintains in her work¹⁹ that Eliot read grounding himself *not* on metric notation *but* on Pound's notion of *melopoeia*, which seems paradoxical to me) but this does not imply the absence of an underlying pulse²⁰, constant from a change until the next. Scrutinizing the audio files of the recordings with a spectrogram software we can notice all the variations in pace that occur during the reading (double-crossing the two recordings we can also notice how intentional and calculated, meaning repeatable, they are), but what are fluctuations "around" the pulse and what are pulse changes?

To overcome this problem I devised an empirical method. First I set a metronome to the ideal *tempo* of a certain section of the poem (let's take for example the *incipit*), then I perform the poem myself without fluctuations. The steadiness of pulse gives to the performance a detached feeling, still it works quite well, for a while. But then something happens. When the reading comes to another section (for example "And when we were children, staying at the arch-duke's") the pulse feels badly wrong. No matter how hard one tries to stretch vocalization: the pulse feels too slow. The other way round is also possible, of course: I set the metronome to the ideal *tempo* of that other (in this case, faster) part of the poem and read it carefully on the beat until, again, something feels wrong and a new change is needed. It may seem a desperate venture, but in truth the results are encouraging. With this method I distinguished a minimum number of three

¹⁹ see Micakovic, 2015, p. 174.

²⁰ regarding the differences between the 1935 and 1946 recordings, I absolutely agree with Chambers (2015) that Swigg (2001) overestimates them and that they prove the strict adherence to a set of rules that had one variation (the shortening, and not disappearing, of the pause at line break). In the later recording Eliot displays more technical control, but the rhythmical interpretation of the poem is not different.

tempi in qualitative reading; these allow a not unnatural (even if robotically straight-to-the-pulse) rendering of all the lines in the poem (except for the quantitative sections examined before), and they also mark the limit between a reasonably instinctive performance technique and one that requires specific musical skills. I will now quote the opening stanza of the poem with the addition of marks **1**, **2** and **3** indicating respectively *larghetto*, *adagio* and *andante tempo* directions, and the colouring of some grammar operators that will come handy later on.

1 April is the cruellest month, breeding
Lilacs out of the dead land, mixing
Memory and desire, stirring
Dull roots with spring rain.
Winter kept **us** warm, covering
Earth in forgetful snow, feeding
A little life with dried tubers.
Summer surprised **2 us**, coming over the Starnbergersee
With a shower of rain; we stopped in the colonnade,
And went on in sunlight, into the Hofgarten,
And drank coffee, and talked for an hour.
3 Bin gar keine Russin, stamm' aus Litauen, echt deutsch.
And when **we** were children, staying at the arch-duke's,
My cousin's, he took me out on a sled,
And I was frightened. He said, Marie,
Marie, hold on tight. And **2** down **we** went.
In the mountains, there you feel free.
I 1 read, much of the night, and go south in the winter.

Is this, however satisfying, anyhow legitimate? What signals, apart from the experiments with metronomes, the right place to change pace? Once again, we are helped by the intimate connection between *tempo* and rhythm. If we analyze the rhythmical structure of the different parts, we effectively discover a coincidence between the varying in number of syllables per line and the shift of pulse. With this I don't mean that every time there is a change in foot a change in pulse also occurs, but that it happens when the prime divisors of the number of syllables change. This is called metric modulation, a musical tool that can be applied to poetry. This is not the only way the changing of speed may be detected. The slowing down back to *adagio* and eventually *larghetto* is flagged by the grammar operators "we" and "I"; this will be explained in the next paragraph, where, considering semantics, I try to give a more encompassing definition of Eliot's triadic framework pulse $\Leftrightarrow \mu\acute{\epsilon}\tau\rho\omicron\nu \Leftrightarrow$ voice.

So, free verse contains directions for *tempo* changes. When the metrical structure of the lines shifts, it can be either to an equally divisible number (for example "Lilacs out of the dead land, mixing / Memory and desire, stirring" goes from ten to eight half beats without breaks) or to a differently divisible number (for example "A little life with dried tubers. / Summer surprised us, coming over the Starnbergersee") the latter compelling the reader to change speed (or to abandon musicality altogether).

There are good reasons to think that Eliot was aware of the metric modulation possibilities of free verse before beginning work on *The Waste Land*, because the idea of applying metric modulation to free verse has been extrapolated from the analysis of the works of Ezra Pound²¹. Moreover, the quatrain poems that predate *Gerontion* and *The Waste Land* could be easily explained in the perspective of an author cultivating the intention of working with free verse with such rigour (being this idea of free verse actually a hybrid verse it requires maximum precision with the working of the regularly rhythmized components; moreover, protesting that the substance of his poems wasn't hiding behind the eccentricities of free verse, he hoped for more appropriate and serene criticism of the complex free verse he had in mind)²².

One final observation: the three *tempi* I called *larghetto*, *adagio* and *andante* are not to be understood as very detached slow, medium and fast *tempi*, but rather as medium-slow, medium and medium-fast. The ratio between each and its immediate faster neighbour is easily obtainable ("A little life with dried tubers" places eight beats where "coming over the Starnbergersee" places nine): 8/9 (for example 64 / 72 / 81 bpm), which finally explains the ratios in *tempo* changes we found earlier, relatively to quantitative metre. We discovered that those three *tempi* were defined by this proportion: $a=3/4b$, $b=3/4c$, whereas the proportion relative to the qualitative system is $a=8/9b$, $b=8/9c$. This allows us to calculate the product of ratios (constant), which again is the *hemiola* ratio 3/2; this means that both within-quantitative and within-qualitative *tempo* changes are built with the same ratio, that is itself describing the proportion of bar lengths between the two groups²³.

III. Throbbing phonetic semantic psychedelic

I will now move from the realm of signifiers to that of signified. What does a change of pulse convey? Why does Eliot change pulse in determinate points of the poem? Has this any connection to the meanings he wants to channel?

I have looked for correspondences between changes in pulse and semantics, and I discovered some revealing conformity: it is a systematical shift of grammar operators (meaning the shifting in reference between the same grammar operator and different addressees without what would be the proper grammatical break) that triggers the change in pulse (particularly relevant when the change doesn't affect the metre). Before trying to infer a general rule concerning grammar operators, I will recall Eliot's essay *The Three Voices of Poetry*, speculating that the change of pulse is a change of voice, precisely in the sense he clarifies in his text. The three voices represent respectively: the inner and truer (only partly voluntary) thought of the poet; the outward rhetorical mask that a subject presents to the public without opening up (like that of a talk show host or of a

²¹ see Langman, *Cutting a Shape in Time* (2002), pg. 19.

²² "It is, in fact, just this adaptability of metre to mood, an adaptability due to an intensive study of metre, that constitutes an important element in Pound's technique." Eliot, (1917).

²³ apparently, all quantitative reading in the poem has the starting value of the *adagio tempo* (for example 72 bpm) but changes more decidedly to 96 and 54 bpm in its variants. We could so resume the *tempi* table as proportionate to these ratios: 64 *larghetto*, 72 *adagio*, 81 *andante* (qualitative, 2/4); 54 *lento*, 72 *adagio*, 96 *andante moderato* (quantitative, 3/4). This explains the relationship between the 3/2 ratio in beats per measure and the 4/3 ratio in *tempo* regarding the weieleias: $4/3 * 9/8 = 3/2$.

politician); the dramatic rendition of a character other than ourselves (like the imitation of somebody else). It's not apparent, but there is a difference of speed and rhythm among these groups of voices, even if they can accelerate and slow down from their starting, peculiar *tempi*. The first voice is inherently slower, sometimes pausing to consider its own products; the second is slightly faster, but with an opposite relationship to pauses, which are used for rhetorical effect and not for sincere reflection; while the dramatic, dissociated voice is fastest, more prosaic; its poetical attainments are to be counterfeited as random.

With an interesting overturning Eliot places the stream of consciousness on the mouth of the other, with a scheme even closer to an *ante litteram* Lacan than to Freud²⁴. If this third voice slows down, feigning the first voice of another subject, it comes to vacuousness, revealing its *simulachrum* existence, not unlike a *golem*. The beginning of the poem, which we clustered earlier, is exemplary in this sense. Right as if Eliot wanted to adequately stretch his vocal cords, giving us an overall view of the tools he's going to employ (and helping us to better orientate ourselves later on in the poem), we follow the speaker of the poem operate full ranging acrobatics, from the slow and poetic (clearly aimed to communicate universal truths, classically worth of a serious composition to convey), to the fast and prosaic and obscure (blotting out the reader, as cut behind the strongest fourth wall, wherefrom to peep a privy spectacle), back to the slow and poetic (but this time unconsciously so, with the apparent intention of nothing more than a personal note and no manifest interest for universalisms, urging to communicate, at tops, with an intimate confidant). At the same time it moves from singular to plural, then to a different plural and back to a different singular, then to a third, also different (but with one of its elements in common with the second one) plural; common element (Marie) which is that singular we finally end up to.

What does Eliot achieve with these "singular/plural" switches? He goes from a subject's thought to his memories of an absent other, to the memories of another absent other's conversation that include her memories of another absent that was not personally known by the original subject, finally coming "back home" to inner reflection, save for having changed what was outer with what was inner half the way through. Exactly in the middle of the process, when the "us" meaning Marie and Tom becomes the "we" meaning Marie and her children relatives, there is the mysterious²⁵ insert of a foreign and unexpressed "I" ("*Bin gar keine Russin*" etc). It is remarkable that the masculine stays all at one end of the stanza, the feminine all at the other, and the promiscuous dance of plurals in the middle (split in two by the German line). Parading all the shades of his mimetic powers, the speaker goes out of itself and "hides" inside an almost perfect other (who, contrarily to the non-dissociated speaker of the beginning, has no intention of writing a poem; the result is nevertheless poetic and the meaning maintains coherence: I go south in the winter, *thus* April is the cruellest month); nevertheless, in doing so it actually gives us a perfect description of itself: if the other is female, it itself is male. This association

²⁴ see Rimbaud, *Lettre du Voyant* (1871), and Lacan, *Fonction et champ de la parole et du langage en psychanalyse* (1953).

²⁵ after many wrong interpretations, claiming first that the line was taken from Marie's conversation, then that it was a manufactured symbol of post-war Europe; it was finally recognized as the most obscure reference to a short novel by H.G. Wells: see Mason, *The Lithuanian Whore in The Waste Land* (1989). It is likely that Eliot didn't intend the reader to get the reference but to remain astonished in a determinate way; but why then using a quotation at all? And why Wells'? Is there a magical intention in Eliot's poetry?

between self and masculinity and other and femininity is very strong, even if there are no closed doors in the poem. The other's masculinity appears as the oracular voice (the perfect description of the process is the ambiguous Madame Sosostriis, who presents us exactly a woman—the other—with a man's voice), while femininity of the self is shunned, till the protagonist is sexually used by Mr. Eugenides²⁶ in *The Fire Sermon* and his identification with the raped daughters overcomes the resistance. This enables him to identify with the oracular voice, becoming Tiresias and keeping, from that point until the very last page, a much stabler position, without further mimicry²⁷.

Conclusions

Differentiating between *accelerandi*, *rallentandi* and *rubati* on one side, and base *tempo* changes on the other, I claim that there is a stricter correlation between typesetting (and metre) and Eliot's recordings of the poem—that are in my opinion two not very different interpretations of a text that is meant as a score, however incomplete (like every score always is)—than mainstream exegesis currently assumes.

The discovery of two ternary sets of *tempi* (governed by ratios built exclusively out of integers two and three, ingrained by the congenital quantitative/qualitative metre ratio: Greek/English=3/2) underlying the recordings and the metric structure of complex free verse constructions, and a correlation of those ternary sets to grammatically “unjustified” shifts between operators and addressees, drew me to look into Eliot's definition of the “three voices of poetry”, that strikes me as a later meditation about a *praxis* first developed between 1917 and 1921 as an incorporation of some of Pound's techniques.

Eliot didn't want to emphasize the maths involved for at least three good reasons: first he didn't want to get caught in a too constraining web of rules, second he wasn't merely following Pound (who was most committed to the topic) but pursuing his own instinct, third he didn't want to give away his method. What is really relevant for the thesis contained in this paper is not that these rules are followed exactly in the text and reading performance as if they were an end; on the contrary, it is meant to defend the idea that these (or such) ideal rules were used by Eliot while imagining the poem and referred to as guidelines when creating its most daring *exploits*; so much so that even recordings made decades later by the non-musician that he was see an overwhelmingly predominant accomplishment of their constitutional proportions. So the ternary sets of *tempi* should be used in future explorations as “filters” in the analysis of the metrics of the poem and of the drafts, to draw hypotheses about Eliot's method of writing and organizing the work in process.

I like moreover to underline that the opposition of a male first voice and a female third voice, or that of a male first voice outside of the fourth wall and that of a female first voice decidedly inside the fourth wall, brings me to conclude that the speaker in the poem has some determinate characteristics, and first of all is not a plural (even if he surely is a multitude). The succession of the three voices tells us that we are dealing with an unchanging subject mimicking somebody else, whereas the changing within the same

²⁶ see *The Waste Land - A Fac-Simile and Transcript of the Original Drafts etc* (1971) pg. 47 line 190.

²⁷ for a constructivist analysis of mythical method as opposed to allegory in a horizontal dichotomy of *The Waste Land* (and of Eliot's *oeuvre* in general), see Serpieri, *T.S. Eliot: le strutture profonde* (1985).

voice means that we are being narrated of a metamorphosis: the negation, acceptance and going insane (or pretending so) of a same subject.

Using the tool of musical interpretation I therefore claim that the speaker of *The Waste Land* is one, that he is male and that his conscious image of the self changes during the poem (through a different circuiting with his feminine side) with consequences to his experience of reality. My understanding of the ending of the poem is that this new clarity persuades him to estrange himself from the human kind, indefinitely but not conclusively.